

Plumbing Emergency Budget — Action Checklist

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BEFORE YOU CALL A PLUMBER

- ☐ **Ask about emergency surcharges, after-hours multipliers, and trip charges before committing to a service visit because emergency plumbers charge 2-3 times their standard rate once the clock starts ticking.:** Ask about emergency surcharges, after-hours multipliers, and trip charges before committing to a service visit because emergency plumbers charge 2-3 times their standard rate once the clock starts ticking.
- ☐ **Know that standard plumber hourly rates range from \$85 to \$150 depending on location and experience level so you can evaluate whether a quoted price is reasonable.:** Know that standard plumber hourly rates range from \$85 to \$150 depending on location and experience level so you can evaluate whether a quoted price is reasonable.
- ☐ **Build a relationship with a plumber before an emergency happens because they will often do small jobs at flat rates rather than charging you the full emergency minimum billing increment.:** Build a relationship with a plumber before an emergency happens because they will often do small jobs at flat rates rather than charging you the full emergency minimum billing increment.
- ☐ **Get written quotes from at least two plumbers before authorizing any repair work so you have a baseline to compare against and aren't pressured into immediate decisions.:** Get written quotes from at least two plumbers before authorizing any repair work so you have a baseline to compare against and aren't pressured into immediate decisions.

GETTING AN HONEST QUOTE

- ☐ **Request a flat-rate quote instead of hourly billing whenever possible because flat-rate pricing protects you from paying extra if the job takes longer than expected.:** Request a flat-rate quote instead of hourly billing whenever possible because flat-rate pricing protects you from paying extra if the job takes longer than expected.
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- ❑ **Ask the plumber to explain whether the damaged pipe is accessible or hidden before agreeing to repairs because hidden pipes inside walls or slabs can cost 5-10 times more than accessible ones.:** Ask the plumber to explain whether the damaged pipe is accessible or hidden before agreeing to repairs because hidden pipes inside walls or slabs can cost 5-10 times more than accessible ones.

- ❑ **Find out the age of your water heater and calculate repair versus replacement costs when facing a water heater bill over \$500 because units over 10 years old often make more sense to replace.:** Find out the age of your water heater and calculate repair versus replacement costs when facing a water heater bill over \$500 because units over 10 years old often make more sense to replace.

- ❑ **Decline any 'while we're here' repair suggestions until you get itemized pricing because add-on services suggested during a visit are a common source of inflated emergency bills.:** Decline any 'while we're here' repair suggestions until you get itemized pricing because add-on services suggested during a visit are a common source of inflated emergency bills.

PROTECTING YOURSELF AT PAY TIME

- ❑ **Understand that most plumbers charge a 1-hour minimum even for 15-minute jobs, so a \$10 part replacement can easily become a \$150 service call on your invoice.:** Understand that most plumbers charge a 1-hour minimum even for 15-minute jobs, so a \$10 part replacement can easily become a \$150 service call on your invoice.

- ❑ **Ask for a time estimate before authorizing diagnostic work on complex issues like hidden leaks because you are billed for every minute the plumber spends investigating.:** Ask for a time estimate before authorizing diagnostic work on complex issues like hidden leaks because you are billed for every minute the plumber spends investigating.

- ❑ **Get all pricing components including parts, labor, surcharges, and trip charges documented in writing before work begins so you have grounds to dispute the final invoice if needed.:** Get all pricing components including parts, labor, surcharges, and trip charges documented in writing before work begins so you have grounds to dispute the final invoice if needed.

- ❑ **Verify whether the trip charge is applied to your repair bill or charged separately as a non-refundable diagnostic fee because this distinction can add \$50 to \$150 to your total.:** Verify whether the trip charge is applied to your repair bill or charged separately as a non-refundable diagnostic fee because this distinction can add \$50 to \$150 to your total.